

Though many different religious sects and movements have flourished briefly throughout history, five great faiths have emerged and spread sufficiently to become major world religions.

Hinduism

The oldest of these five religious faiths is Hinduism, which has a range of very diverse traditions but no formal system of beliefs. The origin of the religion can be traced to about 1500 BCE, when it is believed that Aryan horsemen from Central Asia invaded the Indus Valley in northern India (see pp.58–59), accompanied by a creator god Indra and a pantheon of lesser deities (see p.143). These were the Vedic gods, who feature in the *Vedas*, the

3,000-year-old sacred texts that are central to the development of Hinduism. The religion evolved to focus on three main gods: a senior, somewhat remote deity called Brahma; Vishnu the creator; and Shiva the destroyer, along with their various consorts or *shaktis*.

From the 6th century BCE, Brahmanism became the dominant form of Hinduism and triggered the composition of the Brahmanic, Epic,

“There is probably no subject in the world about which **opinions differ** so much as the nature of religion.”

JAMES FRAZER, FROM “THE GOLDEN BOUGH,” 1922

and the Israelite elite deported to Babylon. Cyrus the Great (see p.93) allowed the exiles home in 539 BCE to form a religious state based on the Hebrew book of law (the Torah) and the Jewish

no fixed abode,” later known as Hebrews, came together under Moses and settled in Palestine. In 587 BCE Jerusalem, the city that the legendary King David had made the capital of Israel, was destroyed by the Neo-Babylonians (see p.92) and

IDEA

MONOTHEISM

The religious faith of the Israelites rested in a universal god, a unique, unchanging, and physically unseen revelation that contrasted starkly with the polytheism of neighboring cultures in the ancient Middle East. Tradition has it that this omnipotent deity, also the God of Islam and Christianity, was first recognized by Abraham—one of the patriarchal ancestors of the Israelites.



Spreading the Faith

In the first millennium BCE the scope of religions, supported not just by local traditions, but by sacred writings, widened immensely. Hinduism and Buddhism spread across Southeast Asia, while the Middle East saw the expanding influence of Judaism, followed by its monotheistic offshoots, Christianity and Islam.

Holiest of holy sites

Christianity, Islam, and Judaism view this site in Jerusalem as holy. In the foreground people can be seen praying at the Western Wall, and behind it is the Dome of the Rock mosque.

and Puranic literature, including the great texts of the *Mahabharata* and *Ramayana*. Hinduism remains polytheistic (see BEFORE).

Buddhism

Buddhism emerged not as a belief in a god, but as an ascetic way of life. Its teachings involve the belief that death marks the transition to a new earthly life—reincarnation. The only way to escape this painful cycle of death and rebirth, known as *samsara*, is to achieve perfection, which is accompanied by an extinction of passions, or *nirvana*.

Buddhism evolved in part as a reaction against polytheistic Hinduism and attracted a body of disciples willing to practice asceticism (abstention from earthly comforts). The historical Buddha (distinguished from earlier wholly mythical characters) was born into the royal Shakya clan in northeast India (modern Nepal) in about 563 BCE. After his death in about 483 BCE his original companions established the *Theravada* (“doctrine of the elders”) school that would become the basis of more conservative Buddhist teaching.

The first monotheistic faith

Judaism, the monotheistic (see above right) religion of the Jews, evolved from the older, ritualistic, temple-based cult attributed to Moses. The ancestors of the Jews, the wandering Israelite tribes or *habiru*, literally “people of

religion flourished, first under Persian control, then under Alexander the Great (see pp.96–97). When one of Alexander’s successors, Antiochus Epiphanes, tried to introduce aspects of Greek cults, the resulting uprising led to a dynasty of priest-kings, the Hasmoneans. In 63 BCE Greater Judea was incorporated into the Roman order, and hard times followed, culminating in 70 CE when much of the population of Jerusalem was scattered (see p.146).

Followers of Jesus Christ

The second major monotheistic religion, Christianity, arose from Judaism. There is no evidence that Jesus envisaged

founding a religious movement. It was only through his death on the cross, during which Christians believe he atoned for humanity’s sins, that the early Church emerged. The first Christians met in private houses and had no formal dogma; only after several decades did formal places of worship appear. The new religion endured spates of often bloody persecution from orthodox Jews and also from Roman emperors, notably Nero in 64 CE and Domitian at the end of the 1st century CE. Rather than destroying the religion, however, persecution had the effect of reinforcing the convictions of its devotees. >>

RELIGIOUS FIGUREHEAD (c. 4 BCE – c. 30 CE)

JESUS

Jesus of Nazareth was the inspiration for the religious movement of Christianity, which derives from Greek *christos*, synonymous with Hebrew *messiah*, meaning “a chosen one.” Jesus probably saw himself as a social reformer, but to some Jews under Roman occupation he became the deliverer predicted in Jewish scripture. In the Christian gospels he is described as the son of God. For much of his life Jesus moved around the Sea of Galilee, accompanied by a local band of disciples and followers. Only after his journey to Jerusalem and his death by crucifixion did his following grow and his messianic fame spread.

